



Dr. Montek Singh Ahluwalia, Deputy Chairman, Planning Commission with Chief Minister Pawan Chamling during International Florishow 2008

On Sikkim being declared the Emerging Tourism State:

"Sikkim is one of the most fascinating eco-tourism destinations in the world. We depict the real story of continuity amidst change. We take pride in being the living example of unparalleled and the most successful sustainable practices. Our development foundation is mainly based on eco-tourism characterized by amazingly fabulous and charming natural resources. Our growth is triggered by traditional farming practices that produce a magnificent variety of horticultural, floricultural and ethno-medicinal items. With a negligible use of chemical fertilizer, we have been the harbinger of organic farming in the country."

Chief Minister Chamling said, "Eco tourism means encouraging tourism and yet keeping nature not tampered with, I also mean the people of Sikkim."

"Look at our natural heritage. With over 4000 species of striking varieties of plants and shrubs and around 700 species of rare orchids and rhododendrons, we are one of the top bio-diversity hotspots in the world. We are storehouse of very rare medicinal and aromatic plants. I am told that the American people pretty much like Ringad (wild fern and what we locally call Nigro) and water crest (what we locally call Simrayo). We traditionally grow both of these in highly organic condition. Our passion fruits, ginger and cardamom are of unparalleled quality and flavour."

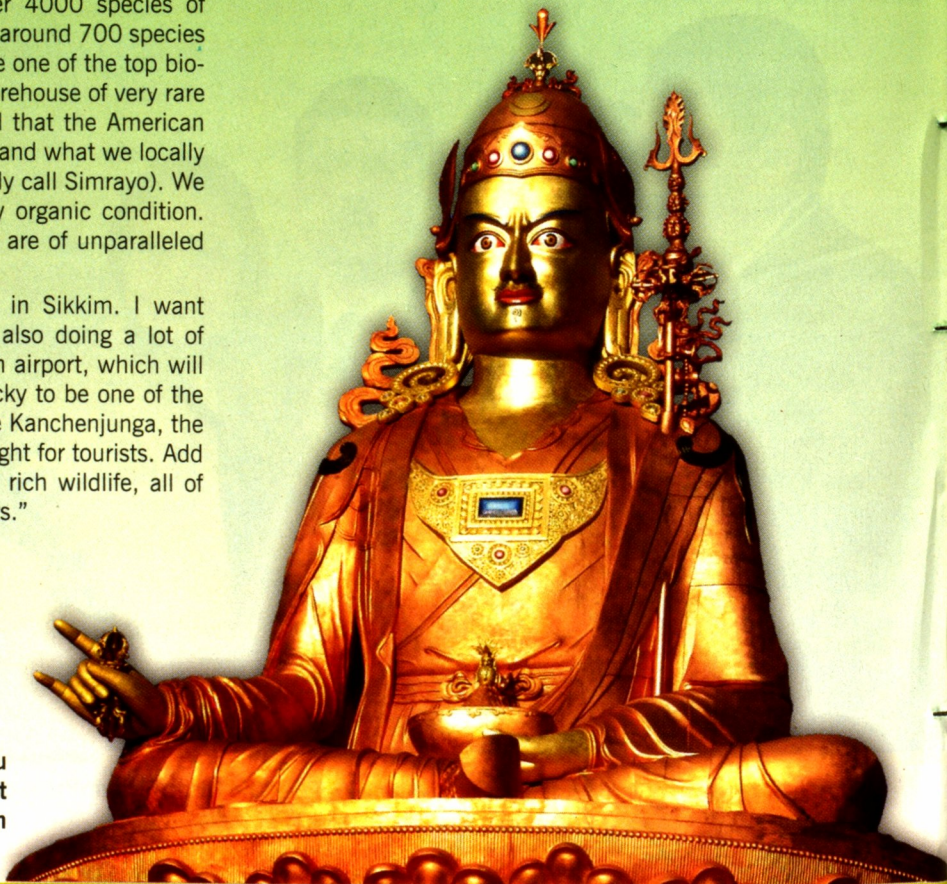
"Tourists will find peace and tranquility in Sikkim. I want to continue working towards this. I am also doing a lot of construction work. We are constructing an airport, which will make Sikkim more accessible. We are lucky to be one of the most beautiful parts of India. We have the Kanchenjunga, the world's third highest peak, which is a delight for tourists. Add to this the beautiful mountains, glaciers, rich wildlife, all of which are a source of attraction for tourists."

On Capacity Building in Sikkim: Looking ahead, Mr Chamling said that the capacity-building and empowerment of the Sikkimese people is a big priority. Since 2003, Government has created Skill Development Fund and later Directorate of Capacity Building for the first time in Sikkim to undertake training for youths in various disciplines to make them self-employed or make them capable of harnessing opportunities arising outside government establishment. Besides sponsoring and coordinating hosts of training programs for our young Sikkimese within and outside India, the Directorate also provides educational loan of upto Rs. 30 lakhs for overseas courses and Rs. 10 lakhs for educational program within India to poor students whose parents can not afford the cost of education on their own.

Apart from establishing a Directorate of Capacity Building, various state government departments allocate and keep aside 2 percent of their annual outlay for capacity building programmes. The Chief Minister requested the government departments to embark on the capacity building mission immediately and stressed that the programmes must be result-oriented.

"I initiated the Capacity Building Directorate to ensure skill learning and professional training for its youth. We are further planning to have a full-fledged Institute of Capacity Building during the next financial year."

"This capacity building also has training in all professional skills. It is the responsibility of the directorate to focus on the youth while they are still undergraduates. At this stage, trained counselors decipher each student's skills and are put on to career counselors thereafter. In other words, the youth get to know about their own capacity through the directorate"



Stature of Lord Guru Padmasambhava 135 ft at Samdruptse, Namchi, South Sikkim